

DARK HORSE PK in Raghopur, Vaishali, as part of the Bihar Badlav Yatra, Oct. 11

ANI

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fielding the late *bahubali* Mohammed Shahabuddin's son Osama Shahab as evidence of the RJD's legacy of intertwining crime and politics (in Darbhanga, he called the MGB alliance a "*thug-bandhan*"). Meanwhile, a report by the Association of Democratic Reforms and Bihar Election Watch says 65 per cent of BJP candidates have criminal cases registered against them; the figure is 76 per cent for the RJD.

The NDA is also attacking Tejashwi's 'one government job per family' promise. Shah was among the first to call it "a baseless promise that defies all conventional accounting". Assuming one member each from 25 million families gets a government job, the annual salary bill would be at least, according to Shah, Rs 11.7 lakh crore, nearly four times Bihar's current budget of Rs 3.17 lakh crore. Tejashwi says he has worked out the blueprint with experts, and will present it to the people soon. Fiscal fantasy or not, the fact remains that the pledge has made jobs, or the lack of them, the core emotional issue of this election. It has also exposed a raw nerve in the NDA's flanks as it lists achievements of the past 20 years.

OTHER HINDRANCES

Besides the BJP's formidable election machinery, Tejashwi has to reckon with two other forces—resurgent Dalit leader Chirag Paswan, who is repositioning himself as the "youth face of Bihar", and political strategist-turned-politician Prashant Kishor, who, though a new entrant, is expected to eat into the vote share of both alliances. Chirag, who nurses chief ministerial ambitions, has aligned himself with the NDA this time, assuring them of the 5 per cent Paswan vote. Kishor's Jan Suraaj campaign has, by all accounts, found some resonance among sections of Bihar's youth, and even a modest turnout in his favour could unsettle both coalitions. In the 2020 state polls, the NDA and MGB had together secured 74.5 per cent of the vote. This left a volatile 25.5 per cent scattered among independents and smaller parties. Kishor's strategy is to capture a slice of that unclaimed quarter, and alter the geometry of power. In a state where 50 seats are often decided by margins of less than 5,000 votes, even a single-digit statewide share could transform Jan Suraaj into a spoiler for both sides.

For the Congress and Left allies in the alliance, Tejashwi is now the undisputed face of the MGB. As the Congress's peace broker Ashok Gehlot said rather succinctly, "Tejashwi is our collective choice because he represents continuity and change—both of which Bihar needs." This is also his best chance, with Nitish seemingly ailing and the BJP without a clear leader. If he loses, Tejashwi's claim to Bihar's future leadership may dim irreversibly. If he wins, he becomes not only the state's new face but also the Opposition's most credible youth leader in the Hindi heartland.

But it won't be easy. Even as the campaign set off in right earnest in October, a Delhi court, helped by a CBI chargesheet from October 2024, framed charges against Lalu and his family in an alleged land-for-job scam, accrued from his tenure as Union railway minister (2004-09). Tejashwi, too, has been named, which the RJD leader calls "pure political vendetta", claiming the timing, just weeks before polls, was "no coincidence". The optics will hurt, but this is just another front as he takes on the combined might of the BJP-JD(U)—a political juggernaut fielding half a dozen national and regional heavyweights. In this battle for Bihar, Tejashwi Yadav stands almost alone, the solitary spearhead of the MGB campaign. ■